

Social identity and music: A search for moral autonomy and personhood in pop culture

For Vernon Press

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Assessment of the manuscript

originality 2

rigour 1

impact 1

Having read the manuscript for *Social identity and music* my overall assessment is that while the text is rich and builds on an interesting combination of moral philosophy, different strands of theory, and different contemporary music genres the manuscript needs major revisions focusing on readability to be published. This is no critique of the content or idea. The manuscript lacks explanations of the method(s) used, what material it builds on, definitions of central concepts, and lacks guidance for the reader to be able to follow the 150 pages. I will develop some clarifying comments below.

Originality

· Does the manuscript draw from the right strands of literature?

The manuscript might be using the right strands of literature but could deepen its explanations of why these scholarly texts are used and how they function together. Moral philosophy, feminist ethics of care, theoretical discussions of authenticity in country music are three examples of literature the manuscript draws on. I am missing thorough explanations of these scholarly debates that are large, a clear position of the author that explains how they will be used in the existing manuscript, and a discussion on how they will be combined. The impression is scattered. It is unclear to me what literature is used where and why. It is unclear what field this book wants to contribute to.

· Does the author appropriately acknowledge prior academic literature?

Yes and no. The author appears to be well-read in several fields and the references seem appropriate. But many of them could be explained better. And some of the discussions in the book is not supported with literature at all. For example, on page 31 where the author starts analysing contemporary rap lyrics. Studies of rap and hip hop is a large scholarly field that is not used or explained well in this analysis.

· Is the literature review comprehensive or (at least) balanced? Feel free to suggest specific additions to literature, as long as they make a clear contribution to the main thesis of the book.

No, there is no section that I understand as a literature review. I would recommend having such a section where the literature the book draws on is presented in one chapter and explained well. Now new concepts and references to (very) different types of work appear all over the manuscript. I do not want to decide what should be included there. I do recommend the author thinks through what fields they are drawing on and present them well.

· Does the manuscript claim to be an original contribution? How justified is such a claim?

No, the manuscript makes no hyperbole claims. I think it is original, but in need of editing for clarity on a foundational level. I find the manuscript hard to follow.

· Does the manuscript have other scholarly value e.g. as a synthesis of existing knowledge
Yes, it does. But after editing and explaining the knowledge it draws on better.

Rigor

· Is the study sufficiently focused? Does the manuscript read like a cohesive whole?

No. The manuscript is unclear on many accounts. I am sure the author knows what they want to say – but it is not coming through. One example of how this appears in the manuscript is through the central questions presented on page 1: “the value of moral testimony for knowledge, and b) how to appropriately respond to morally laden situations in fiction, as a source of moral knowledge”. These two questions are presented as the main questions of the book but they do not revolve around music, popular culture, social identity, or personhood as the title of the whole book suggests. It is up to the author if the title should change or the questions. Further, I do not believe the book is structured around either the title or those two questions. The structure of the book is very unclear. Music is introduced on page 17. Here country music is stated to be the topic. The manuscript is full of these types of mismatches between what is introduced and how it is followed up and the text to come. The chapter structure is another example of something that confuses me. A table of contents and headlines stating “Chapter 2” etcetera would help a lot. The manuscript lacks foundational structure.

· Does it draw from appropriate forms of evidence?

No. The evidence and material are very vague. I am not sure what music it draws on and how after having read the whole book. It seems that narratives in music lyrics as a sort of fiction is the evidence/material in focus. But what lyrics are included, from what times, places, artists, why those were chosen, and how they are analysed is unclear.

· Is the method used appropriate for the objectives of the study?

No method is explained or introduced. From the content I believe there is a narrative text analysis method being employed, at least at times. But that method and why it was selected is never discussed.

· Is the method applied well? You could for instance suggest alternative interpretations of the results, robustness checks or alternative methods.

No. There is no structure in how examples of lyrics, fiction and music are analysed and presented. Perhaps the manuscript should be read as a philosophical essay that has more flow than a traditional academic book. Still, that should then be explained to the reader.

· Are any limitations of the study adequately documented?

No. In general the manuscript does not follow the kind of standard rules applied to academic publishing. The editor and publishing house could see this as a strength and a genre choice. But it does make it hard to give a positive review while answering the questions set up for reviewers.

Impact

· Is it ambitious?

Yes. The strength of the book could be the combination of strands of research and thought applied. But it needs revisions to make more sense to the reader.

· What disciplines or strands of literature are likely to appreciate/welcome the proposed book's contribution?

Maybe moral philosophy is the main strand in the book. Even if the title suggests it is music and identity that angle is not fully realised in the manuscript.

· Does it hold potential for classroom adoption?

No. The style of writing that explains little and leaves the reader confused would not work for students.

· Does the work carry significance for audiences beyond academia (such as professional, public policy)?

No.

· Is this a work of social relevance?

Perhaps it could be, if it was easier to understand.

Other aspects to consider

· Is it logically structured? Is it well written? Does it include appropriate and sufficient visual aids(figures/charts/tables)? Does it contain factual errors?

The main weakness of the manuscript is the writing and the structure. While reading the manuscript different theories, questions, materials and arguments are introduced on almost every page. They are not coherently discussed, references are lacking, the material and main argument are both unclear. I do believe there is a book in this manuscript but it needs a lot of editing for clarity and the author needs to decide what the book is about. Because I think it is impossible to write a coherent book on all of the topics the manuscript introduces at the same time.